

Think Before Moving a Pawn

Track the squares a pawn gains, the support it leaves, and the position after exchanges.

WHO THIS BOOK IS FOR

Players who know how the pieces move and want to make better decisions. Use a board if notation is new. Books 01-08 need no endgame theory; read Book 09 before the more demanding rook examples in Book 10.

THREE LESSONS. EACH HAS A MODEL, AN EXERCISE AND AN EXPLAINED ANSWER.

01 Will the pawn still be supported?

P. 3

02 Aim the break at a supporting pawn

P. 6

03 Create a passer, then count the race

P. 9

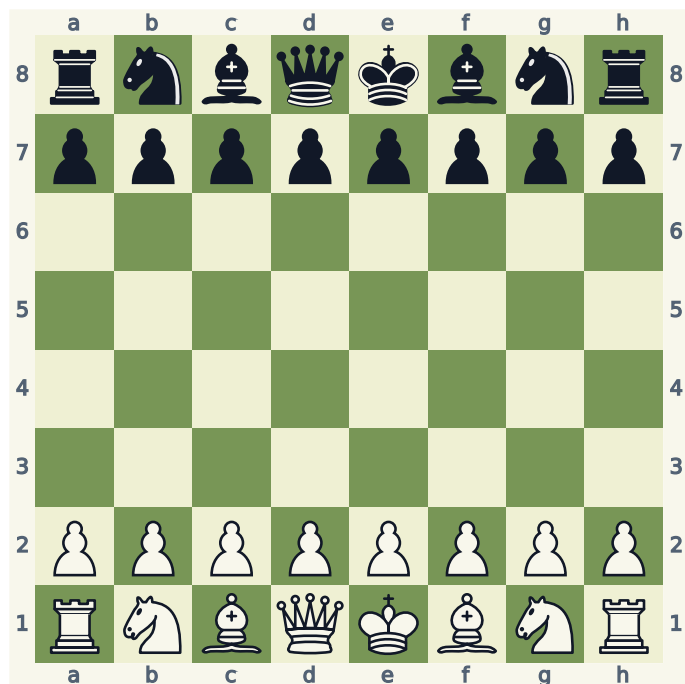
A practical study session

Spend 5 minutes reading the model, 5 minutes solving without the answer, and 5 minutes explaining the solution aloud. Spend another 5 minutes playing the position from both sides. Study one lesson per day; repeat its exercise tomorrow and a week later.

What counts as learning: name the relevant fact, show the opponent's reply, and explain what remains. A move guessed without a reason earns only partial credit. The goal is a repeatable decision, not a memorized diagram.

Use the board, then the move list

Every diagram says who moves. Boards face that player; file letters and rank numbers remain authoritative.



NOTATION YOU WILL SEE

1. K = king, Q = queen, R = rook, B = bishop, N = knight. A pawn move has no piece letter.
2. Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. Rxc6 means a rook captures on c6.
3. + means check; # means checkmate. O-O means kingside castling. e8=Q means promotion to a queen.
4. 1... means Black moves first in that line. Read one move, make it on a board, then read the reply.

THE SAME THINKING ROUTINE IN EVERY CHAPTER

1. Check the immediate threat.
2. List two sensible candidates.
3. Test the opponent's checks, captures and threats.
4. Inspect the final board: material, king safety, piece activity and pawn structure.

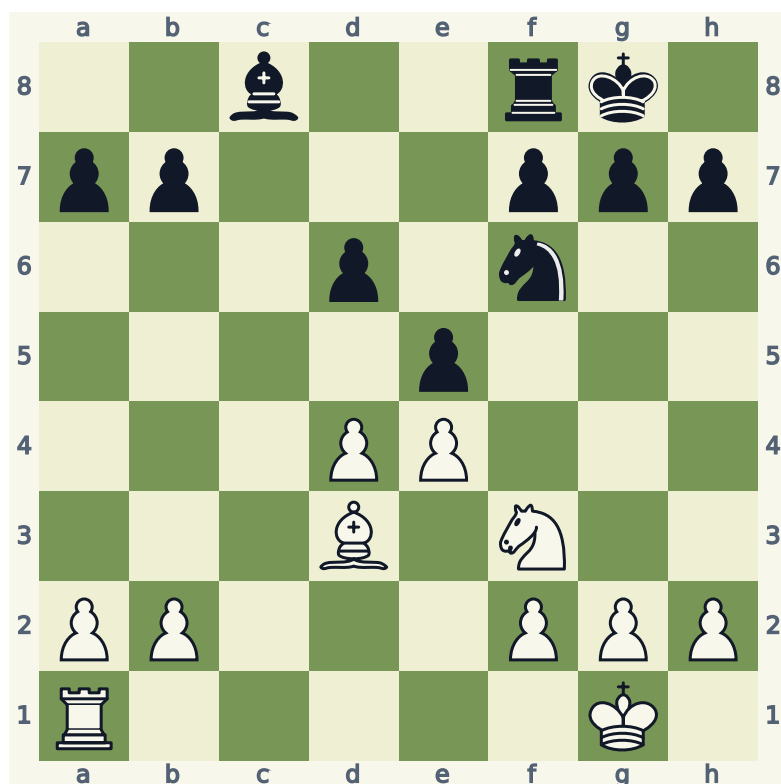
Read the claim carefully. A sample line may illustrate a plan without forcing every reply. Some exercises ask for a safe move, a legal move or a correct diagnosis rather than a unique best move. A tablebase gives an exact result for the specified small ending; an engine check supports a line but is not a proof of every strategic claim.

Replay and revisit. The web edition includes every explanation. Download its PGN file to load the model and exercise positions into a chess program; each starts from a FEN position code. No account or software is needed to read the PDF or website.

Will the pawn still be supported?

A pawn move changes the squares it attacks forever. Before advancing, inspect its new support and the squares or pieces that depended on its old location.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's e4-pawn attacks d5, so it can support a pawn that advances there.
2. Black's knight on f6 also attacks d5.
3. White's bishop on d3 protects e4, helping maintain the supporting pawn.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. d5 a6

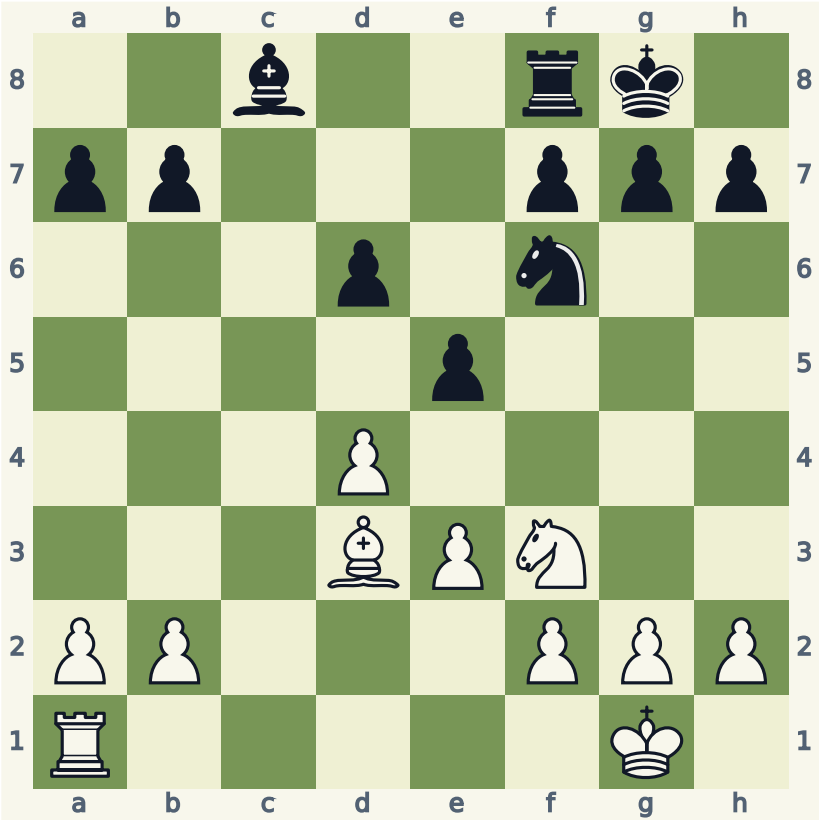
After d5, White gains space and fixes the central pawns. The black knight cannot win the d5-pawn for free: ...Nxd5 would allow exd5, exchanging a knight for a pawn.

The illustrative ...a6 leaves the supported center intact. This is a structural example, not a claim that d5 is best in every similar position. White has also closed lines and given up the option of keeping the central tension with d4 against e5.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



1. Which pawn changed, and which square does it now defend?
2. Calculate d5 through Black's simplest capture.
3. Give a bishop move that keeps the pawn chain and avoids a possible ...e4 fork of bishop and knight.

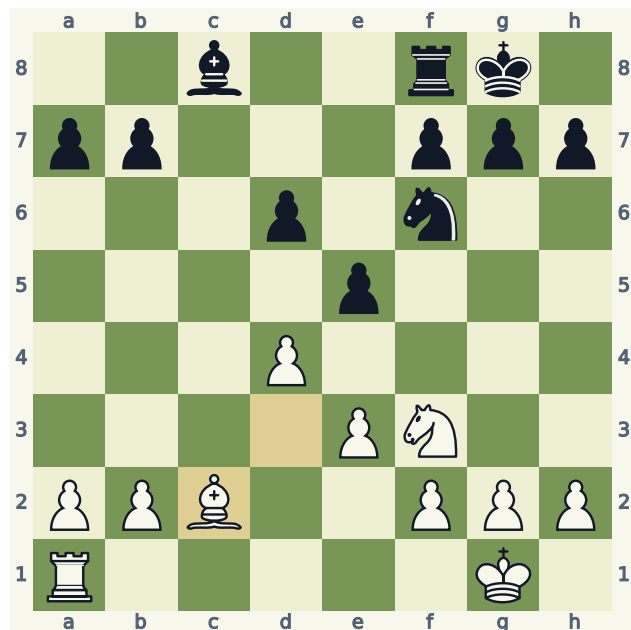
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 2b2rk1/pp3ppp/3p1n2/4p3/3P4/3BPN2/PP3PPP/R5K1 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. Bc2

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. The e-pawn is on e3. From there it attacks d4 and f4, so it supports the pawn only while that pawn remains on d4.

2. After d5, ...Nxd5 wins the pawn. White's e3-pawn cannot recapture on d5, and neither the bishop on d3 nor knight on f3 attacks d5.

3. Bc2 moves the bishop off d3, so ...e4 would no longer attack both bishop and knight. The e3-pawn continues to support d4. A full decision would also compare central captures; the essential answer is why this position calls for care before the unsupported d5 advance.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Support is specific to the new square. A pawn on e3 protects d4, but it does not protect d5. Count the defenders after the advance, not before it.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

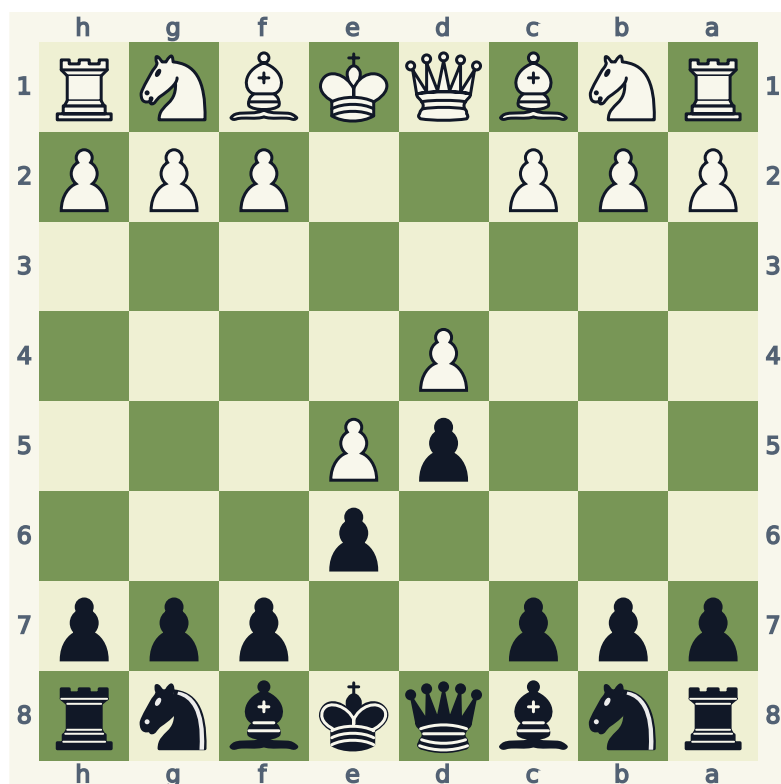
Before your next five pawn moves, name the square the pawn stops defending and the piece that will defend its destination. Review any move for which you could not answer.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Aim the break at a supporting pawn

A pawn break challenges an enemy pawn structure. Attacking the support of an advanced pawn can be more practical than attacking that advanced pawn directly.

MODEL A / BLACK TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White's d4-pawn supports the advanced pawn on e5.
2. Black can advance the c7-pawn two squares to c5 because both intervening and destination squares are clear.
3. A pawn on c5 attacks d4, the base of White's central chain.

WORKED SEQUENCE

3... c5 4. c3 Nc6

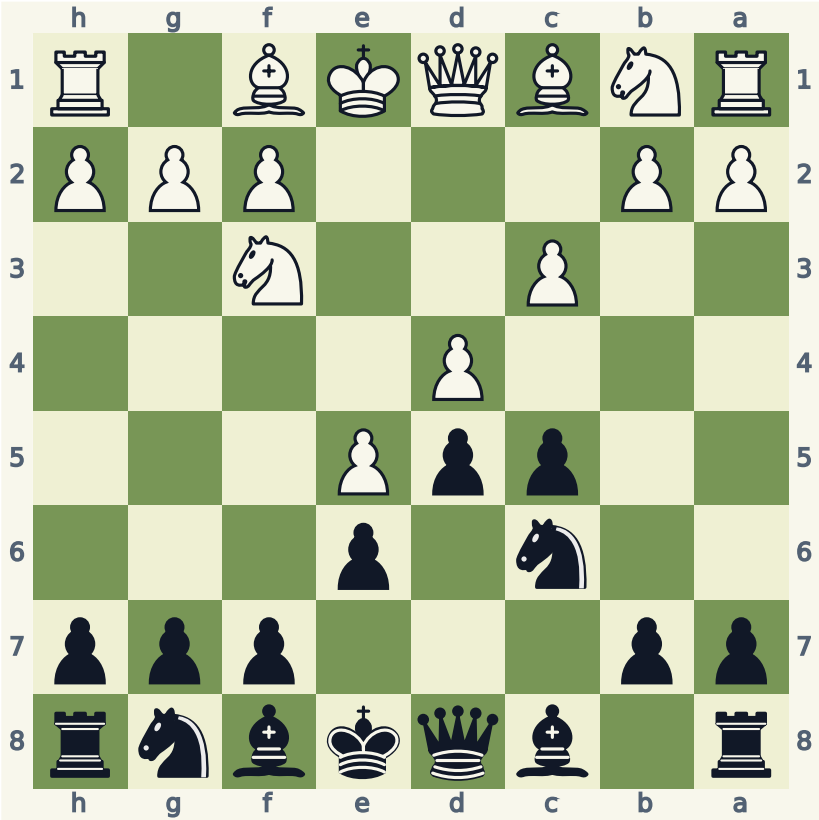
...c5 challenges d4. White often reinforces with c3, and ...Nc6 adds another attacker to d4. Both sides have a clear job: Black increases pressure; White maintains the support of e5.

The break is not a promise to win a pawn immediately. White can defend, exchange, or change the center. Black should calculate what remains after each exchange and coordinate pieces with that structure.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / BLACK TO MOVE



1. After ...cxd4, which white pawn can recapture on d4?
2. Does that recapture leave the e5-pawn unsupported?
3. What has changed even though the central chain remains?

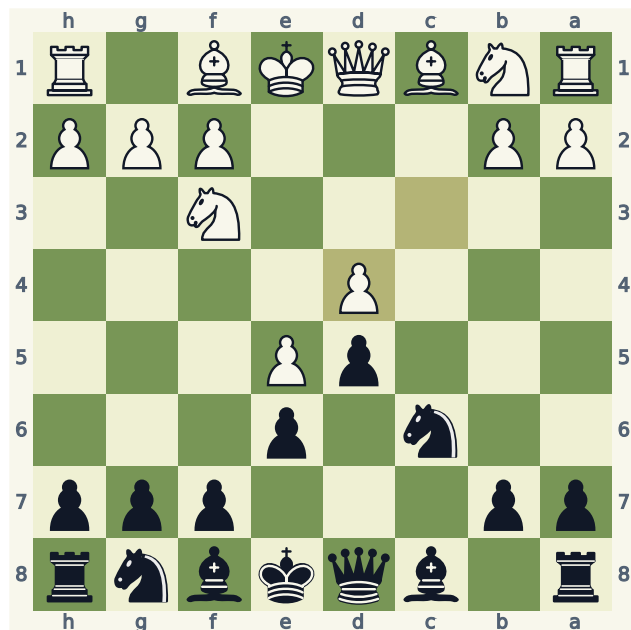
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): r1bqkbnr/pp3ppp/2n1p3/2ppP3/3P4/2P2N2/PP3PPP/RNBQKB1R b KQkq - 2 5

Check your reasoning

5... cxd4 6. cxd4

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. White's c3-pawn can play cxd4. The original white d-pawn disappears, but the c-pawn takes its place on d4.
2. No. A white pawn on d4 attacks e5 regardless of which file it started on. The chain d4-e5 still exists after the exchange.
3. The c-file has lost both c-pawns, creating an open file, and the identity and future flexibility of the center have changed. Black must plan for the resulting position instead of claiming the base was simply removed.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Trading a pawn off its original square does not always destroy the structure. A recapturing pawn may replace it and keep the same supporting relationship.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

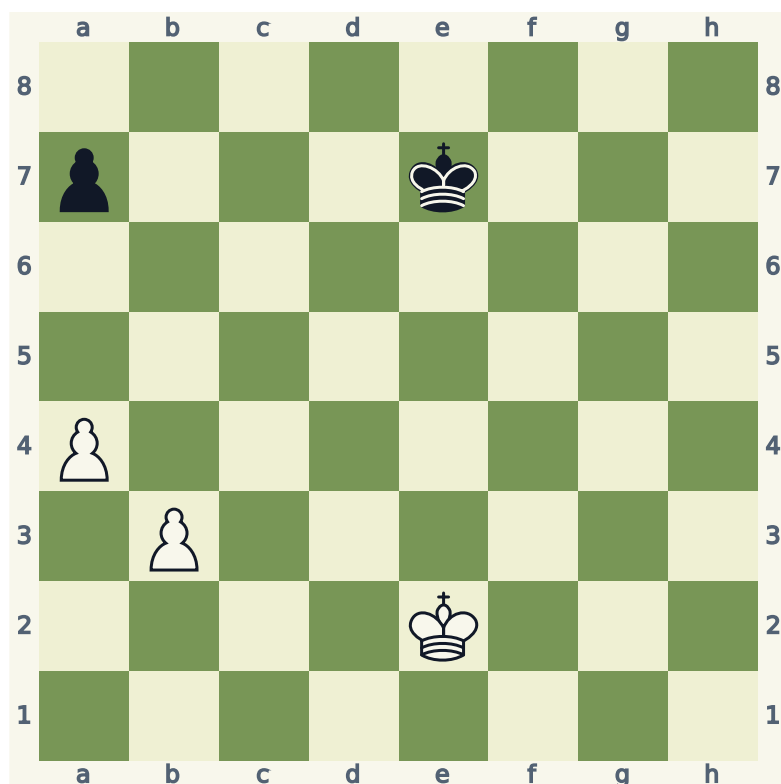
Replay one pawn exchange from an opening you use. Freeze the board after all recaptures and describe the open files, pawn support and new targets.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Create a passer, then count the race

A pawn majority can create a passed pawn, but a passer is an asset rather than a result. Count the opposing king's route and any counter-pawn race.

MODEL A / WHITE TO MOVE



READ THESE FACTS FIRST

1. White has two queenside pawns against one.
2. The b-pawn can advance beside the a-pawn and offer an exchange.
3. Black's king is far from the queenside at the start, but can approach as the pawns move.

WORKED SEQUENCE

1. b4 a6 2. b5 axb5 3. axb5

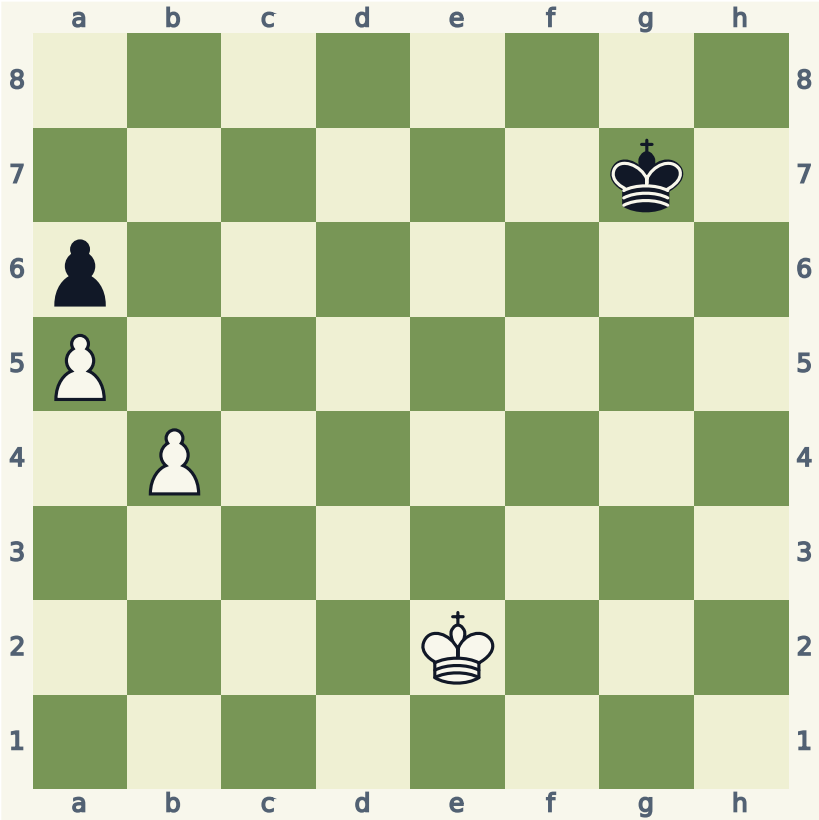
The illustrative sequence b4 ...a6 b5 ...axb5 axb5 leaves White with a passed b-pawn: no black pawn remains on the a-, b- or c-file to stop it.

That line demonstrates creation, not a forced win. Black could choose different moves, and this starting position is a tablebase draw with best play. To win a pawn ending you must also defeat the king's blockade; counting a two-to-one majority is not enough.

Your turn: inspect the changed position

Work for five minutes before turning the page. Write the reason and the opponent's reply, even if you recognize the pattern.

EXERCISE B / WHITE TO MOVE



1. What is the idea of b5 in this more advanced position?
2. After ...axb5, why is a6 stronger than trying to recapture?
3. Count the promotion race in the sample line. What must Black also consider besides accepting the pawn?

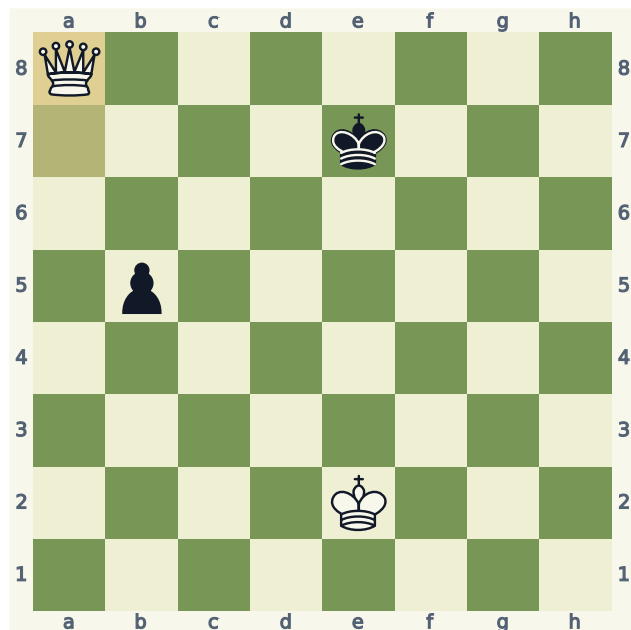
MY CANDIDATE, THE REPLY I EXPECT, AND THE REASON

Position code (FEN): 8/6k1/p7/P7/1P6/8/4K3/8 w - - 0 1

Check your reasoning

1. b5 axb5 2. a6 Kf7 3. a7 Ke7 4. a8=Q

EXERCISE B / AFTER THE SAMPLE LINE



1. b5 offers the b-pawn to divert Black's a6-pawn away from the a-file. White's a5-pawn can then become a passer.

2. The a5-pawn cannot capture a black pawn on b5: a white pawn captures diagonally to b6. Instead a6 starts a fast race, followed by a7 and a8=Q.

3. After ...axb5 a6 ...Kf7 a7 ...Ke7 a8=Q, White promotes before Black's king arrives. Black can decline the capture, but the exact starting position with the king on g7 is still a tablebase win for White. The distant king is a decisive detail; Model A is only a draw.

WHERE THE IDEA CAN FAIL

Do not assume the opponent will capture your offered pawn. Compare accepting the exchange with advancing the king or keeping the pawns locked. The defender chooses the most difficult reply.

TRANSFER TO YOUR OWN GAMES

Set up both diagrams and count moves for the pawn and defending king separately. Then play against a tablebase without assuming the defender accepts a pawn sacrifice.

Score your explanation: give 1 point for the relevant fact and 1 for the consequence in each of the three answers (6 total). At 4 or below, replay the model and try again tomorrow. A different legal plan can earn full credit when it satisfies the question and survives the opponent's reply.

Remember it without the diagram

CLOSE THE BOOK. ANSWER THESE THREE QUESTIONS FROM MEMORY.

1. Why is d5 supported with a pawn on e4 but not with one on e3?
2. Why can ...cxd4 fail to remove support from e5?
3. What is the difference between creating a passer and winning?

CHECK YOUR ANSWERS AFTER YOU HAVE TRIED

1. The e4-pawn attacks d5 diagonally; the e3-pawn attacks d4 instead.
2. White can recapture cxd4, replacing the supporting pawn on d4.
3. A passed pawn has no opposing pawn blocker, but the king or a counter-race may still stop it.

Checking and scope. Original teaching positions and explanations, with standard opening sequences where indicated. All 6 starting positions and listed moves in this book were checked for legality. Stockfish 19 reviewed candidates at depth 18; available positions with 7 or fewer pieces were also checked against the Lichess tablebase. Strategic examples do not claim unique best play. These AI-assisted materials are not a substitute for checking an unfamiliar continuation on a board.

PRIMARY REFERENCES AND FURTHER PRACTICE

[Lichess practice: tactics and endgames](#)

[Lichess opposition practice](#)

[Lichess basic rook endgames](#)

[Stockfish: official engine](#)

[Lichess tablebase API](#)

Edition 1.0 | 2026-09-10 | Lesson text: knightway8. Chess piece artwork: Colin M. L. Burnett (Cburnett), GPLv2+. Full artwork source, credits, position data and validation notes are in the repository. Report a correction with the book, lesson ID and exact move.